



REUTERS

and I had to walk away before it got even worse.

Since the time I was nine, I've been playing until I was 34. Even now, there are a few days when I think I have to go to train and then I realise that I don't need to do that anymore. Now I think, come on, live your life. So I'll eat something unhealthy. But even these days, that old guilt will come in when I do that, and I'll feel bad for a while.

Do you miss the training?

Just because I'm no longer playing

doesn't mean I can stop training. The only thing is that I'm not preparing for a tournament. I'm just putting in the work so I can be pain-free now! If I don't train, my body will be in even more pain than it is!

How easy was it to switch off from competitive badminton?

I always thought that I wouldn't be able to switch off the mentality of being an athlete, but it happened. In the first year, it felt strange, but after the second and third years, it started feeling normal. When you aren't

playing competitively, how long will that fire last? I was surprised when it happened to me as well. I talked to (Parupalli) Kashyap, and he told me, 'Yeah, that fire will go away.' My parents told me the same thing. I didn't believe it was going to be possible. It might have been true for other people, but it wasn't for me.

But that's exactly how it was. After two years away from the sport, I'm okay.

Sometimes the past almost feels like a dream. The years went by so fast! When I see my matches, it